First News

24 Mar 2026

Employing Intelligent investing, a disciplined, long-term approach to wealth creation based on fundamental analysis, risk management, and emotional control.

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Global, Regional Markets

Wall Street staged a relief rally after reports that the U.S. military was told to delay potential strikes on Iranian power plants and energy infrastructure, giving room for continued diplomatic negotiations.

Stocks rallied as Trump halted strikes on Iranian energy sites, signaling potential de-escalation in the Middle East. Cooling tensions eased oil price fears and global recession risks, boosting investor confidence

S&P 500 and Nasdaq 100 were testing "pivotal support"; the sudden news triggered a massive wave of Dip Buying S&P 500 (SPX): Emerging from Extreme Oversold March 20 RSI: 23.34 (Deeply oversold). Nasdaq 100 (NDX): Testing the Oversold Boundary March 20 RSI: 26.10.

US has held talks with Iran & suspended any further airstrikes for five days, sending oil prices tumbling.

- Iranian officials and media have denied such talks.
- Gold pares losses, nearing $4,330, while silver trims earlier declines of amid mounting inflation concerns.

Bitcoin is higher by 3.52%. After months of gains from a weaker dollar and rate cuts, bonds have reversed—down over 5% since the Iran war began, nearly double the losses of their dollar peers, as inflation fears and rising yields hit prices.

Mitsubishi UFJ Financial Group, Inc. (MUFG), is one of the world’s leading financial groups, says current USD/PHP base-case forecast of 58.00 by 4Q2026 assumes a resolution after March 2026, oil prices falling toward $70 per barrel levels

Opportunity? Or Not?

- Major World indices are approaching or have entered technical correction territory (a 10% drop from recent highs). Persistent uncertainty on inflation, global energy supply disruptions creates a "risk-off" sentiment that may lead to further declines.

US President Trump said Iran had 48 hours to reopen the Strait or have its power plants attacked, while the Islamic Republic responded with a threat to shut down the key waterway for crude supply.

DA MARKET SECURITIES

Asia-Pacific

	3/23/2026	3/24/2026	%Chg
Dow Jones	45,577	46,208	1.38%
S&P 500	6,506	6,581	1.15%
NASDAQ	21,647	21,946	1.38%
PCOMP	6,018.00	5,899.00	-1.98%
NKY	53,372.00	51,515.00	-3.48%
SHCOMP	3957	3813	-3.64%
HSI	25,277.00	24,382.00	-3.54%
KOSPI	5781	5405	-6.50%
SENSEX	74,532.00	72,696.00	-2.46%
TWSE	33,543	32,722	-2.45%
ASX200	8428	8365	-0.75%
BURSAKLCI	1720	1720	0.00%
JCI	7106	7106	0.00%
STI	4848	4841	-0.14%
SET	953	929	-2.52%
VNINDEX	1647	1591	-3.40%

DA MARKET SECURITIES

Commodities - Metals & Agriculture

	3/23/2026	3/24/2026	%Chg
WTI Crude	98.23	89.78	-8.60%
Brent Crude	112.19	100.92	-10.05%
Gold (Comex)	4845	4465	-7.84%
Silver (Comex)	76.59	69.58	-9.15%
Platinum Spot	1928.6	1893	-1.85%
Copper (Comex)	537.45	548	1.96%
Nickel	7.5848	7.5373	-0.63%
Nickel Ore Phl 1.5%	80	80	0.00%
Nickel Ore Phl 1.8%	94.5	94.5	0.00%
Coal	146.5	140.5	-4.10%
Corn	465.5	461.25	-0.91%
Wheat	595.25	592	-0.55%
Cocoa	3255	3180	-2.30%
Sugar	15.7	15.52	-1.15%

DA MARKET SECURITIES

Strategy

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Asia and Philippines

Shares of Asian miners fall, tracking a broader slide in metals prices triggered by growing fears of inflation from the extending conflict in the Middle East.

The damage to Qatari LNG infrastructure is creating a ripple effect that benefits oil refiners and coal producers as the world scrambles for alternative energy.
WATCH: PCOR, SHLPH, SCC

USD/PHP at 60.26 — it's no longer just about rising oil prices. A prolonged closure of the Strait of Hormuz points to a broader energy shortage, Philippines exposed, BSP unlikely to hike rates, depend on whether the oil shock proves temporary or persistent inflation driver.

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Philippines Sells TBills, Yield Rises
P3.71B 364 Day at 5.166%
P9B 182-Day at 5.032%
P9B 91-Day at 5.004%

Market Closed Monday 3/23/26
Miners/Oil, Holdings, Property, Financials, Industrials & Services Capitulated!!!
167 stocks declined, 46 advanced & 58 unchanged
Value traded at P8.043 Billion

Global Investors 3/23/26:
Net Buyers Monday jgs mynld ceb aev fcg keepr ew cic dhi apx px ap ceb cnvrg ogp rrhi acen at aev pcor nikl cosco
Net Sellers Monday bdo ali sm mbt ict jfc bpi smph ac tel plus gtcap mer urc wlcon dmc mwc ltg sgp pgold

DA MARKET SECURITIES

Philippines

Employing Intelligent investing, a disciplined, long-term approach to wealth creation based on fundamental analysis, risk management, and emotional control,

5899 -119pts., -1.98%

Range 5,816-5951

Breadth 46(+) 167 (-) 58 (unch)

Block Php948Mn **Volume** 1.35bn
Value Php8.17bn

Share buyback sm ict opm spmh meg

52wk H: fpi ipm sgp
52wk L: ab alhi ali allhc alter ara bdo bloom bpi cts eei eli gsmi medic om pal rci sevn sm tech ubp vlc

Overbought – fpi
Oversold – tech ali gtcap pha sm lbc bpi mbt ogp imi ferro fli rci now

Active	Value
ICT	1280
BDO	798
ALI	591
MBT	469
SM	326
BPI	295
JFC	243
SMPH	226
APX	209

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DA MARKET SECURITIES

Foreign Trade

NFB(S)	$22.242mn
Total Month FS	$15.041mn
YTD NFB	$195.467mn
FB	4,028,354,795.69
FS	5,368,920,643.56
NFB(S)	1,340,565,847.87
TOTAL	9,397,275,439.25

Foreign Funds Bought
aub bncom ew dhi slf acen acr ap mynld pcor fcg keepr pizza cic aev cosco jgs areit creit rcr rlc shng cnvrg ceb mac sti bloom web mrsgi apx at fni marc nikl ogp px

Foreign Funds Sold
bdo bpi cbc mbt pnb secb ubp alter crec fph mer mwc scc sgp shlph top axlm cnpf dnl jfc monde rci urc green imi aba ac agi dmc gtcap ltg sm smc ali mrc mreit pha smph dito glo tel ict plus pgold wlcon

Share Buy-Back Transactions 3/23/26
OPM AGI URC SMPH

Smart Watch: Energy
mer aslag top pcor apl sgp crec spnec

10yr Bond	3/23/20...	3/24/2...	%Chg
PHL	6.748	6.989	3.57%
US	4.235	4.358	2.90%

Currency Pair	3/23/2...	3/24/2...	%Chg
USD-JPY	159.29	158.26	0.64%
USD-PHP	59.898	60.298	0.06%
USD-CNY	6.8917	6.8798	0.24%
EUR-USD	1.1492	1.1633	-0.35%

NEWS, ANALYSIS , INVESTING INSIGHT

BANKS

- Philippine banking sector maintains a robust, high-profitability, & asset-growth trend, total resources rising by 7.3% to a record ₱36.33 trillion in January 2026, driven by a stable, consumer-driven economy.

ALI 17.32 17.26 RSI 23.53
SMPH 19.28 RSI 35.58

- **YOUR PROXY TO PHILIPPINE PROPERTY**

SMC

- SMC Infrastructure is providing temporary relief by granting toll rebates to specific vehicles on the South Luzon Expressway (SLEX) and STAR Tollway. This initiative, which lasts for two months, is designed to offset recent toll hikes and ease the impact of rising fuel costs.
- SMC core net income rises 52% to P79.6 billion in 2025

CEB 29.95

- **CEB (Cebu Pacific / Cebu Air) FY2025 Net Income +128% to ₱12.3B; Suspends 5 Routes to October on Fuel Shock**
- Cebu Pacific's net income more than doubled to ₱12.3B in 2025 (+128%), as total revenues rose 14% to a record ₱119.9B. Operating income increased 25% to ₱11.5B. The airline flew a record 26.9 million passengers (+10%), supported by an 84% seat load factor. Cargo revenues grew 27% to ₱7.2B. EBITDA rose 21% to ₱30.9B, expanding EBITDA margin to 26%.
- However, CEB is suspending five international routes and scaling back frequencies on nine others after jet fuel costs "more than doubled compared with 2025 averages." Routes suspended include Davao–Bangkok (April 13–October 23), Iloilo–Bangkok (April 17–October 24), Iloilo–Singapore (June 15–October 23), and Clark–Hanoi (May 2–October 25).
- **Analysis:** This is a tale of two stories in a single earnings release. The FY2025 results are genuinely strong — a 128% profit surge driven by capacity discipline, fleet modernization (A330NEO and A321NEO economics), and cargo growth. The 26% EBITDA margin is airline-sector-competitive.
    - But the forward picture is sharply complicated by the Middle East fuel shock. Jet fuel having more than doubled vs. 2025 averages directly attacks CEB's cost structure — fuel is typically 30–40% of airline operating costs.
    - The 5 route suspensions and 9 frequency reductions are a rational response: better to cut routes now than to operate at a loss and destroy the balance sheet. The suspended routes (Bangkok, Singapore, Hanoi, Clark) are primarily Southeast Asian leisure routes — presumably lower-yield markets not worth operating at current fuel prices. The key watch: whether these suspensions stay temporary (through October) or become structural if Brent stays at $110+. For investors, CEB at current levels is a direct bet on geopolitical de-escalation and fuel normalization. If the conflict drags through H2 2026, earnings could take a meaningful hit vs. the 2025 base.
- **Stance:** NEUTRAL to MONITOR. Record FY2025 earnings are a strong foundation. But sustained Brent at $110+ makes the fuel cost equation deeply challenging for an LCC. Watch Q1 2026 operational updates and any route restoration announcements as the key signal.

NEWS, ANALYSIS , INVESTING INSIGHT

GTCAP 508.50
Exposure to MPI

- MPIC is eyeing over ₱200B in capital expenditures for 2026, nearly double its ₱116B spending in 2025, with the biggest driver being Meralco's solar projects. "For 2026, the biggest capex will really be Meralco to finish the solar plants," MPIC CFO Chaye Cabal-Revilla said. The budget may be reviewed amid geopolitical uncertainties, but no projects have been stopped.
  - The project, led by Meralco PowerGen through Terra Solar Philippines Inc., aims to produce 3,500 megawatt-peak of solar power supported by a 4,500 megawatt-hour battery storage system.
  - MPIC is still sticking to its double-digit growth target for 2026, with the CFO saying: "We're in the process of quantifying the impact to us... We're still sticking to our target, which is double digit growth."
  - FY2025 core net income rose 15% to ₱27.1B.
- **Analysis:** At ₱200B+, MPIC's 2026 capex is among the largest single-year infrastructure investment programs ever committed by a Philippine conglomerate — and it's almost entirely anchored on the MTerra Solar buildout at Meralco. The key distinction: Pangilinan has asked other major MPIC subsidiaries to reassess their budgets, but said he doubts Meralco and MGEN capex will be reduced.
  - This means the RE backbone of the capex plan is ring-fenced. The risk is execution delay, not cancellation. MTerra is the most capital-intensive RE project in Philippine history, and geopolitical disruption to supply chains (solar panels, inverters, BESS components are China-sourced) could push timelines.
- **For investors:** MPIC's FY2025 results (+15% core net income, ₱27.1B) validate the infrastructure cash generation story. The capex cycle is now in its most intense phase — near-term free cash flow will be under pressure, but the post-2027 earnings inflection (as MTerra and other RE assets come online) is the thesis.
- **Stance:** ACCUMULATE for GCTAP for exposure to MPI on weakness. The MTerra Solar capex is the most consequential RE investment in the Philippine power sector. Near-term FCF compression is real; post-2027 earnings uplift from Meralco generation is the re-rating catalyst.

NEWS, ANALYSIS , INVESTING INSIGHT

ICT 698.00

- I**CTSI sold its 51% equity interest in Yantai International Container Terminals Ltd. (YICTL) in China's Shandong province to Yantai Port Holdings Co. Ltd. for RMB773.21M (~₱6.75B). "**
  - After a successful 20 years in Yantai, ICTSI deems the sale of YICTL in keeping with the ICTSI Group's long-term strategy of focusing on concession contracts where ICTSI has control over critical aspects of the business," the company said.
  - ICTSI added the divestment will allow it to "rationalize our strategy and redirect its resources to its other existing projects and those in its pipeline." The sale is not expected to have a material impact on its business, financial condition, or operations.
  - For 2026, ICTSI plans to increase capex by 13.77% to $740M. Shares fell ₱2 or 0.29% to ₱698.
- A**nalysis:** This is a clean and strategically coherent divestiture. The Yantai JV (51% ICTSI, 36.5% Yantai Port Holdings, 12.5% DP World China) was a minority-control joint venture structure where ICTSI lacked full commercial governance, exactly the type of asset its stated strategy avoids.
  - Exiting after 20 years at an independently valued price is disciplined portfolio management, not distress. The ₱6.77B in proceeds is meaningful capital that can be redeployed into new concessions or reduce debt.
  - ICTSI's FY2025 was its strongest ever: net income +23% to $1.05B, revenues +18% to $3.23B, TEUs +11% to 14.5M. The China exit is a de-risking move given US-China trade tensions, Yantai is in Shandong, a major export manufacturing hub that could be significantly affected by tariff escalation. The ₱740M 2026 capex (+13.77%) signals continued growth investment despite the divestiture.
- **Stance:** ACCUMULATE for ICT. The Yantai exit is strategically sound. Proceeds + record FY2025 earnings + $740M capex pipeline = strong medium-term investment case. The minor share price dip (-0.29%) is a non-event.

NEWS, ANALYSIS , INVESTING INSIGHT

ALTER 0.74

- **ALTER (Alternergy) Dupinga 5MW Run-of-River Hydro Goes Live; "Triple Play" Portfolio Completed**
- Alternergy Holdings Corp. commenced commercial operations of its ₱1.7B Dupinga run-of-river hydropower plant in Gabaldon, Nueva Ecija completing its "Triple Play" portfolio of wind, solar, and hydro. The facility will deliver 23,000 MWh of electricity annually to ~13,000 households under a 25-year power supply agreement with Nueva Ecija Electric Cooperative II – Area 2.
- The plant will also reduce carbon emissions by 16,500 metric tons annually. Alternergy's next projects coming online in 2026 are the 128MW Tanay wind farm and 64MW Alabat wind farm adding 192MW to its generating capacity toward its 1GW target by 2030.
- Shares rose 4.23% to ₱0.74.
- **Analysis:** The Dupinga commissioning is a genuine milestone — it's a small plant (5MW) but the strategic significance of completing the Triple Play (wind + solar + hydro) is that it stabilizes Alternergy's generation profile across seasons and weather conditions. Hydro provides baseload stability that wind and solar cannot. The plant is embedded generation for NEECO II Area 2, so it avoids transmission fees and VAT improving the economics vs. the headline tariff. Timing is also favorable: with Brent at $112 and fossil fuel generation expensive, renewables with locked-in offtake agreements are increasingly valuable. The Tanay (128MW) and Alabat (64MW) wind projects are the real earnings re-rating catalysts combined, they add 192MW in 2026 on top of the existing portfolio.
    - Shares at ₱0.74 reflect a market still pricing in execution risk; commissioning progress is the key de-risking catalyst.

NEWS, ANALYSIS , INVESTING INSIGHT

TOP 1.42

- **TOP (Top Line Business Development Corp.) files ₱1.5B Preferred Share Offer; Targets Singapore Fuel Trading Hub**
- Cebu-based fuel retailer Top Line Business Development Corp. filed a registration statement with the SEC for a follow-on offering of up to ₱1.5B in perpetual preferred shares to support its import and trading operations. Proceeds will fund expansion of its supply chain network, including a shift to direct fuel importation through subsidiary Topline Logistics and Development Corp., following the establishment of a trading arm in Singapore. The offering consists of up to 10M preferred shares at up to ₱100/share, with an oversubscription option of up to 5M additional shares. Offer period: May 19–June 1; listing target: June 11. A portion of proceeds will also expand depot infrastructure and storage capacity to support higher import volumes.
- **Analysis:** Top Line is executing a vertical integration strategy from fuel retailer to direct importer that is particularly timely given the current oil price environment. By establishing a Singapore trading subsidiary, TOP gains direct access to regional spot markets, reducing dependence on third-party fuel suppliers and improving margin capture. This is the same playbook larger oil companies use to manage procurement costs. The preferred share structure (perpetual, with fixed dividends) is appropriate given the capital nature of the buildout it avoids earnings dilution while building out infrastructure.
    - Key risk: the current Brent-at-$112 environment cuts both ways it creates urgency for the vertical integration (lower procurement cost = higher margins) but also raises working capital requirements as the company scales import volumes. TOP is a small-cap Visayas-focused play the Singapore hub is a credible step-change in its business model.
- **Stance:** MONITOR for TOP. The vertical integration strategy is sound and the timing is right. Watch for SEC registration approval and June 11 listing. Entry at current levels is for investors with small-cap risk appetite.

NEWS, ANALYSIS , INVESTING INSIGHT

SEC

- **SEC — New Reporting Rules to Improve Transparency and Investor Trust**
- The SEC has implemented its Beneficial Ownership Disclosure Rules of 2026 (Memorandum Circular No. 15, Series of 2025), effective January 1, 2026. Corporations must now report ownership changes within seven days, and new entities must declare beneficial ownership data upon registration. The framework classifies beneficial owners into Categories A to I based on ownership interests and control. False information submissions may result in fines of up to ₱2M and potential corporate dissolution; responsible officers face fines up to ₱1M and five-year disqualification from office.
- **Analysis:** This is a structural governance upgrade for the Philippine capital market and a FATF compliance measure designed to protect the Philippines' standing in the global financial system. For listed companies and their investors, the practical read-through is greater confidence in the accuracy of ownership disclosures, reduced risk of corporate structures being used to obscure control, and faster identification of material ownership changes (7-day reporting). The stricter penalties including dissolution risk mean management teams will take compliance seriously. This reform has long-term positive implications for institutional investor confidence in Philippine equities.
- **Stance:** Sector positive. A governance quality improvement that enhances the PSE's attractiveness to foreign institutional investors. No direct equity catalyst, but part of the broader capital market maturation narrative.

NEWS, ANALYSIS , INVESTING INSIGHT

Foxmont Capital Partners — Eyes ₱4B in Philippine Startup Investments; P1.5B First Close Secured

- **F**oxmont Capital Partners is planning to deploy up to ₱4B in new investments in Philippine startups over the next few years, on top of more than ₱1B already invested locally. "We've already invested over ₱1 billion into the Philippines, and we intend to invest up to ₱4 billion more," said Managing Partner Franco Varona. Foxmont has already secured a ₱1.5B first close for its upcoming fund. Fresh capital will target solutions-oriented startups addressing shifting consumer demands, particularly in underserved sectors such as fitness and lifestyle, where rising middle-class incomes are driving demand. Foxmont's 2026 Philippine Private Capital Report notes that even as Southeast Asia's venture funding cooled in 2025, the Philippines posted 34% growth in private capital a standout divergence pointing to investor confidence anchored on demographics, consumption growth, and long-term expansion potential.
- **Analysis:** The ₱4B Foxmont commitment is a positive signal for the Philippine startup ecosystem at a time when regional VC activity has broadly cooled. The Philippines' 34% growth in private capital against a declining Southeast Asian trend is a genuine divergence worth noting it reflects the structural appeal of the Philippine consumer market (young demographics, rising middle class, high mobile penetration) rather than the speculative capital flows that inflated Indonesian and Vietnamese valuations. For PSE investors, the read-through is indirect but positive: a growing startup ecosystem creates future IPO candidates, strengthens the digital economy (benefiting telcos, fintech, logistics plays), and signals international LP confidence in Philippine market fundamentals. Foxmont's NDC co-investment partnership under the Innovative Startup Act also signals a government-backed co-investment channel that could catalyze deal flow.
- **Stance:** Macro positive for Philippine equity market sentiment and the digital economy ecosystem. No direct PSE play, but positive read-through for GLO, ICT, and consumer names exposed to the growing middle class.

PSE-INDEX STOCKS

PSEi

	3/19/2026	3/23/2026	%Chg
AC	514.00	490.00	-4.67%
ACEN	2.55	2.53	-0.78%
AEV	29.40	29.60	0.68%
ALI	18.28	16.92	-7.44%
AREIT	38.30	38.15	-0.39%
BDO	121.50	116.00	-4.53%
BPI	99.00	97.65	-1.36%
CBC	67.50	66.85	-0.96%
CNPF	36.05	35.50	-1.53%
CNVRG	13.24	12.10	-8.61%
DMC	9.75	9.50	-2.56%
EMI	15.26	15.28	0.13%
GLO	1619.00	1585.00	-2.10%
GTCAP	535.00	508.50	-4.95%
ICT	700.00	698.00	-0.29%
JFC	185.00	177.30	-4.16%
JGS	26.90	26.90	

PSE-INDEX STOCKS

PSEi

	3/19/2026	3/23/2026	%Chg
LTG	14.34	13.92	-2.93%
MBT	64.35	63.85	-0.78%
MER	608.00	610.00	0.33%
MONDE	6.10	6.00	-1.64%
PGOLD	40.00	39.30	-1.75%
PLUS	18.26	17.54	-3.94%
RCR	6.75	6.70	-0.74%
SCC	30.00	29.90	-0.33%
SM	628.00	604.50	-3.74%
SMC	69.20	69.10	-0.14%
SMPH	19.50	19.08	-2.15%
TEL	1300.00	1299.00	-0.08%
URC	64.00	62.75	-1.95%